SMART READER EDITIONS

Designing a Meaningful Life

ADRIAN CHEN

Design & creativity

Designing a Meaningful Life

Adrian Chen

“The life you shape begins with the things you choose to notice.”

A BOOK FOR UNHURRIED MOMENTS

Contents

A small collection of ideas to return to.

01 Design begins with intention 04

02 Start with why 05

03 Remove the noise 06

04 Useful can be beautiful 07

05 Build for real days 08

06 Leave room for surprise 09

07 A kinder constraint 10

Design begins with intention

Good design begins before the first sketch. It begins with a careful look at the life already being lived: the routines, frustrations, workarounds, and tiny moments of delight that reveal what truly matters.

> *The life you shape begins with the things you choose to notice.*

Start with why

To make space for meaning, begin by removing what competes with it. Fewer alerts. Fewer obligations accepted out of habit. Fewer objects that ask for attention without offering anything in return.

> *“The life you shape begins with the things you choose to notice.”*

Beauty is not a layer added at the end. It is the feeling that every part belongs. A useful object, a well-paced day, and a generous conversation can all possess this quiet coherence.

Remove the noise

Beauty is not a layer added at the end. It is the feeling that every part belongs. A useful object, a well-paced day, and a generous conversation can all possess this quiet coherence.

> *“The life you shape begins with the things you choose to notice.”*

Design for the Tuesday when everything goes wrong, not only the perfect morning. The best systems bend without breaking. They welcome you back after absence and make the next step obvious.

Useful can be beautiful

Design for the Tuesday when everything goes wrong, not only the perfect morning. The best systems bend without breaking. They welcome you back after absence and make the next step obvious.

> *“The life you shape begins with the things you choose to notice.”*

Leave a little unfinished. A margin, an open afternoon, a question without an immediate answer. Possibility needs somewhere to sit. Without empty space, even the best plan can become a cage.

Build for real days

Leave a little unfinished. A margin, an open afternoon, a question without an immediate answer. Possibility needs somewhere to sit. Without empty space, even the best plan can become a cage.

> *“The life you shape begins with the things you choose to notice.”*

A constraint can be an act of care. A clear boundary protects attention and gives energy a direction. Choose constraints that help you become more present, not merely more productive.

Leave room for surprise

A constraint can be an act of care. A clear boundary protects attention and gives energy a direction. Choose constraints that help you become more present, not merely more productive.

> *“The life you shape begins with the things you choose to notice.”*

A meaningful life is not a finished artifact. It is a practice of noticing, adjusting, and beginning again. Keep what serves you. Change what does not. Let the design remain alive.

A kinder constraint

A meaningful life is not a finished artifact. It is a practice of noticing, adjusting, and beginning again. Keep what serves you. Change what does not. Let the design remain alive.

> *“The life you shape begins with the things you choose to notice.”*

Good design begins before the first sketch. It begins with a careful look at the life already being lived: the routines, frustrations, workarounds, and tiny moments of delight that reveal what truly matters.